APPENDIX E – Final Project Proposal Assignment and Scorecard

Your assignment should include the following sections:

A reminder of the research problem

Your paper has to open on a brief reminder of your research problem and objectives, your main research question and interconnected questions. This is necessary to evaluate the methodological choices that will be developed in the other sections of the paper.

Research approach

In this section, you describe the type of research you use (e.g., a qualitative study or a quantitative study) and you explain why this is an appropriate approach in relation to your research objective and research question (i.e., why is the method appropriate for answering the research question?). In your explanation you need to make use of and cite methodological literature. In this section, you should not describe different types of qualitative approaches, nor should you describe the differences between quantitative and qualitative approaches. You only need to indicate which approach you use and explain/justify why.

Intended data collection method + data collection instrument

In this section you need to describe the data collection method you intend to use (e.g., a survey for a quantitative study or an interview for a qualitative study). If you are conducting semi-structured interviews, you would need to give some details of this method and why it is appropriate. Next, you need to describe the main elements of the data collection instrument (e.g., for a qualitative study, about which main themes will you ask questions and why about those themes; for a quantitative study, indicate for which variables you will include a measuring instrument, and the source for these measuring instruments) and provide a justification for this decision. Make sure to cite relevant research in your justification of decisions. A draft version of the data collection instrument (e.g., interview protocol including interview questions and introduction (qualitative study); measuring instrument including introduction and instructions for responding to the questions (quantitative study) should be included as an Appendix to this assignment.

Intended sample and sample size

In this section, you need to describe the intended sample and sample size for your study. If you are conducting a qualitative study, you need to give a description of the sampling universe and inclusion and/or exclusion criteria. In addition, you need to indicate the intended sample size. When describing the intended sample size, you need to make use of and refer to sample size guidelines discussed in the literature. It needs to become clear from your description why the proposed sample size is likely sufficient for your study. For a quantitative study, you need to indicate how many individuals you will approach to participate in your study and give some background characteristics of those individuals that are relevant to your study.

<u>Assignment Format</u>

The assignment should be between 2 to 4 pages (excluding references and Appendix), 1,5 spaced, type font 12. The preliminary data collection instrument (e.g., survey or interview protocol) should be included in the Appendix. APA should be applied correctly.

Your assignment is evaluated on the following elements: Research rationale, research approach, intended sample and sample size, intended data collection method, preliminary data collection instrument, writing & APA.

Final Project Research Proposal Scorecard

#	Assessment	Excellent 10>8	Very Good 8>7	sufficient 7>5	insufficient 5>0
10	**APA – Conditional!! (= A grade 'insufficient' triggers an immediate fail')**	· Flawless application of APA (Style & referencing)	· Very good application of APA (Style & referencing) · Very rare errors in APA style do not distract from the paper. · One or two references or citations missing or incorrectly written.	· Acceptable application of APA (Style & referencing) · Rare errors in APA style that do not detract from the paper. · Two or three references or citations missing or incorrectly written.	· Insufficient application of APA (Style & referencing) · Too many errors APA style that detract substantially from the paper.
10	**Significance and management problem**	· Excellent development on the significance of the issue to be studied. · The main purpose of the research is very clear and complete. · Excellent explanation of the management problem; it is clearly specific, manageable, and understandable by non-experts.	· Very good development on the significance of the issue to be studied. · The main purpose of the research is clear and quite complete. · Very good explanation of the management problem; it is clearly specific, manageable, and understandable by non-experts.	· Sufficient development on the significance of the issue to be studied. · The main purpose of the research is clear enough and quite complete. · Sufficient explanation of the management problem; it is specific, manageable, and understandable by non-experts.	· Insufficient development on the significance of the issue to be studied. · The main purpose of the research is unclear and key items are missing. · Insufficient explanation of the management problem; it is not specific enough or manageable, and understandable by non-experts.
15	**Theoretical framework**	· Excellent definition of key terms that is rooted in literature (theoretical framework) · The conceptual framework is well delineated. For quantitative studies (or mixed methods, the final conceptual model and hypotheses are presented)	· Very good definition of key terms that is rooted in literature (theoretical framework) · The conceptual framework is well delineated. For quantitative studies (or mixed methods, the final conceptual model and hypotheses are presented)	· Sufficient definition of key terms that is rooted in literature (theoretical framework) · The conceptual framework is satisfactorily delineated. For quantitative studies (or mixed methods, the final conceptual model and hypotheses are presented)	· Too limited definition of key terms that is rooted in literature (theoretical framework) · The conceptual framework is not clear enough. For quantitative studies (or mixed methods, the final conceptual model and hypotheses are presented but wrong or are presented partially – but does not allow the understanding of the approach)- or are not presented at all.
10	**Research rationale.** **(RQs, sub-RQs and objectives + final conceptual models/framework)**	· Flawless overarching (main) research question (quantitative or qualitative) that flows naturally from the conceptualization and management problem. Flawless logic between the different parts. · Flawless and very relevant sub-research questions clearly connected to the main RQ. · A very clear research objective is assigned to each sub-RQs, objective that is achievable.	· Very good overarching (main) research question (quantitative or qualitative) that flows naturally from the conceptualization and management problem. Very good logic between the different parts. · Very good and relevant sub-research questions clearly connected to the main RQ. · A clear research objective is assigned to each sub-RQs, objective that is achievable.	· Acceptable overarching (main) research question (quantitative or qualitative) that flows sufficiently from the conceptualization and management problem. Sound logic between the different parts. · Good and relevant sub-research questions connected to the main RQ. · An understandable research objective is assigned to each sub-RQs, objective that is achievable.	· Insufficient overarching (main) research question (quantitative or qualitative) that does not flow naturally from the conceptualization and management problem. Insufficient logic between the different parts. · Sub-research questions not sufficiently connected to the main RQ. · Poor research objective is assigned to each sub-RQs, objective that is achievable.

10	**Technical design: research approach + method (e.g., case study, mixed methods, interviews)**	· Excellent justification of the research approach (i.e., why the design chosen is qualitative, quantitative, mixed…; philosophical approach...); it is perfectly aligned with the nature of the research. · Excellent defense of the research method chosen	Very good justification of the research approach (i.e., why the design chosen is qualitative, quantitative, mixed…; philosophical approach...); it is well aligned with the nature of the research. Very good defense of the research method chosen	· Sufficient justification of the research approach (i.e., why the design chosen is qualitative, quantitative, mixed…; philosophical approach...); it is sufficiently aligned with the nature of the research. · Good defense of the research method chosen	· Insufficient justification of the research approach (i.e., why the design chosen is qualitative, quantitative, mixed…; philosophical approach...); its relevance with the nature of the research is insufficient. · The defense of the research method chosen is too limited
15	**Technical design: Data collection instrument (e.g., semi-structured interviews, surveys, observations…)**	· The elicited data collection instrument is explained and developed to a proficiency level. It shows excellent relevance with the research question and makes perfect sense. · Excellent explanation about the development of the main instrument with which the data is collected. · Appendixes are provided.	· The elicited data collection instrument is explained and very well developed. It shows very good relevance with the research question and makes perfect sense. · Very good explanation about the development of the main instrument with which the data is collected. · Appendixes are provided	· The elicited data collection instrument is sufficiently explained and developed enough. It presents a good relevance with the research question. · Sufficient explanation about the development of the main instrument with which the data is collected. · Appendixes are provided	· The elicited data collection instrument is explained and developed in a way that does not allow to understand the research strategy. It is not sufficiently related to the research question. · Insufficient explanation about the development of the main instrument with which the data is collected
10	**Technical design: Sampling**	· Excellent definition of the sample (e.g., justification of inclusion and exclusion criteria - representativeness; size; bias if any; validity)	· Very good definition of the sample (e.g., justification of inclusion and exclusion criteria - representativeness; size; bias if any; validity)	· Sufficient definition of the sample (e.g., justification of inclusion and exclusion criteria - representativeness; size; bias if any; validity).	· Insufficient definition of the sample (e.g., justification of inclusion and exclusion criteria - representativeness; size; bias if any; validity).
10	**Technical design: Data analysis**	· Excellent explanation of how the collected data is going to be analyzed and presented (if relevant). The method of analysis is very well explained and shows strong relevance with the nature of the data and study.	· Very good explanation of how the collected data is going to be analyzed and presented (if relevant). The method of analysis is very well explained and shows strong relevance with the nature of the data and study.	· Sufficient explanation of how the collected data is going to be analyzed and presented (if relevant). The method of analysis is well explained and shows good relevance with the nature of the data and study.	· Insufficient explanation on the intended data analysis process. · The explanation provided are not clear and/or present poor relevance with the study
10	**Technical design: Quality of the research design**	· Excellent defense of the methodology. All quality criteria are well explained and articulated.	· Very good defense of the methodology. All quality criteria are well explained and articulated.	· Sufficient defense of the methodology. All quality criteria are explained and articulated.	· Insufficient defense of the methodology. Poor defense of the methodology. The quality criteria are not well explained and are too few.
	Writing and grammar	· Excellent writing skills and use of academic English. · Paper is coherently organized, and the logic is easy to follow. There are no spelling or grammatical errors and concepts are clearly defined. Writing is clear, concise and persuasive.	· Very good writing skills and use of academic English · Paper is coherently organized, and the logic is easy to follow. There are very few spelling or grammatical errors and concepts are well defined. · Writing is clear and concise · A language model may have	· Sufficient writing skills and use of academic English · Paper is generally well organized and most of the arguments are easy to follow. There are only a few minor spelling or grammatical errors, or few concepts are not clearly defined. · Writing is mostly clear but may lack conciseness.	· Insufficient writing skills and use of academic English · Paper is not well organized and most of the arguments are not easy to follow. There are too many spelling or grammatical errors or concepts are not clearly defined. · Writing is not very clear

		· A language model may have been utilized exclusively for copy-editing purposes. The paper itself is crafted in a personal style, ensuring an engaging and vivid reading experience.	been used for copy-editing. The paper is written in a personal style, making it engaging and vivid to read. The text is still clear and conveys the necessary information but lacks the refinement of the 'excellent' level.	· A language model has been used for copy-editing and text improvement. The paper is satisfactorily written. The writing is functional but lacks the refinement and flow of higher-rated versions. The paper is also slightly less clear or engaging.	and lacks conciseness. · The extensive use of a language model results in a text that is very generic and similar to other papers produced by such models. The paper is vague and does not effectively showcase the quality of the writing. It lacks the necessary detail and clarity to communicate the intended message, leading to a poor reading experience for the assessor.

APPENDIX F - Assessment Criteria Final Project

Introduction - 10%
Context, Focus of the Study, Management Problem, Research Question(s), Theoretical and Practical Relevance, Structure

Theoretical framework - 10%
Quantitative study: conceptualization of concepts in study, development and support of hypotheses, conceptual model
Qualitative study: framing for qualitative study, (sensitizing) concepts, evidence for research questions,

Method - 10%
Research Design, Sample, Data collection Method (e.g., measures, interview protocol) & Procedure, Analysis Strategy, quality criteria

Results - 10%
Quantitative study: Correlation matrix, data presentation and analysis, outcomes of statistical analyses, use of tables and figures, matter-of-fact writing style.
Qualitative study: convincing account, as free of jargon as possible, telling a story (articulates the core findings, provides relevant evidence, provides an interpretation and analysis of the findings with respect to the research question), deals with the tension between brevity and completeness, quotations provide support

Discussion & conclusion - 10%
Quantitative & qualitative research: discussion of findings in relation to theoretical framework (chapter 2), limitations of study, theoretical recommendations, final take-away Qualitative study: extends or develops (parts of a) theory, reflects on the role of the researcher

Practical recommendations - 20% (company supervisor has an advisory role)
Presented in discussion and conclusion chapter – recommendations flow logically from results of study, the recommendations are relevant and clear for practice (i.e., not presented in abstract terms).

Innovativeness - 10%
Creative, inventive, original, new concepts, contributes to new knowledge, particularly novel and relevant to practice
Presentation, Structure, Coherence, Writing, APA 7th - 10%
Next to structure and coherence, the Final Project strictly follows the 'Formatting and Citing Sources in APA 7th edition style'.
Defense 10%
Overall quality of presentation (clear communication of the project**,** good quality power point, kept within the time limits)**.** Answered questions from the committee well.

10.1.1. Grading of the Final Project

Although the assessment criteria may result in several different grades for different parts of the Final Project, one final grade (consensus or average) that reflects the overall evaluation must be determined. **Half grades are also allowed and will be listed on the transcript.** For example, a 7.5 may be given. Rounding off to the next half grade will occur as follows: grades between 6.75 and 7.249 will be rounded off to 7. Grades between 7.25 and 7.749 will be rounded off to 7.5.

- Grade **6** shows a basic pass: the Final Project is basically sound and useful to managers.
- Grade **7** shows that the Final Project is on par with expectations: there may be some clear weaknesses in e.g., argumentation or presentation, but they may be offset by e.g., valuable new data or challenging conclusions.
- Grade **8** shows that the Final Project is above expectations and solid all round: it has a clear focus, sound methodology, an interesting approach, and is presented in a convincing way.
- Grade **9** shows that the Final Project is excellent all round: it displays strong arguments, and its conclusions offer a *significant contribution* to academic research and/or to corporate practice.

o Grade **10** denotes a masterpiece. This grade has seldom if ever been awarded.

APPENDIX F - General Structure for the Final project

These guidelines will help you structure your Final Project paper, whether it is a Company Consultancy or Entrepreneurship project. You will find a general suggestion for structuring the paper, as well as a breakdown of what each section should contain. In most cases, both the company consultancy project and entrepreneurship project fit the same format (referred to below, simply as "consultancy project"). The difference is that for the company consultancy project, you work on a problem statement for someone else's firm, whereas in the case of the entrepreneurship project, you work on a problem statement for your own (potential) firm.
Please refer to the Formatting and Citing sources in APA 7th edition style document for the precise content of each item.

- Cover page

- The title of the report
- The subtitle, if applicable
- The status of the report (MBA thesis, doctoral thesis, MSc in Accountancy thesis, etc.)
- Thesis or In Company Final project
- The name of the author- the date
- Name of supervisor and second reader

- Title page (page after the Cover page)

- The title of the report
- The subtitle, if applicable
- The status of the report
- The name(s) of the author(s)
- The name and address of the University
- The name and address of the company, if applicable
- The date.

- Disclaimer (a standard text is available)

- **Foreword** (optional) – Personal context of paper.

- Table of contents –Table of Tables -Table of Figures - Table of Appendices; Navigation (do not number these pages)

- **Executive Summary – One-page maximum** A structured summary of the final project, in which you briefly include the following components (total length should not be more than one page):

    - Purpose/motivation for study & research question (consultancy project should mainly emphasis the broader practical reason for the research; but they should also stress the theoretical motivation for study)
    - Method/approach
    - Main findings
    - Research limitations

- Practical implications/theoretical implications (main emphasis on practical implications; they should also stress theoretical implications, although on a lesser extent)
- Originality of study

The following sections address quantitative, qualitative and mixed methods approaches. For Design Science Research, please see the note at the end of the document.

- **Introduction** – The introduction should set the context/scene for the Final Project, making sure to cover the following three elements:
  - Reason for the research –This would be to place the topic of study in a broader practical context. Thus, why is the issue you aim to address in this study of broader practical importance (e.g., explain how companies are struggling with a certain issue - you could for example use figures to highlight the prevalence of the issue in a specific industry). Some literature also needs to be discussed in this first section – how does the study fit in the existing research context.
  - The Research problem –This should be the central 'management problem' (e.g., strategic objective) decided on with your company. This problem statement should be translated into a research question.
  - Relevance of the study – Indicate how you aim to contribute to literature and practice. For both types of study, the **practical** and **theoretical** relevance need to be described. However, in the company consultancy project, the focus is on practical relevance.
  - The Structure of the Final Project – Briefly outline the main chapters included in the paper.

- **Theoretical framework** – In this chapter, a theoretical frame should be provided for the study. A theoretical framework based on empirical, conceptual and theoretical work from academic journal articles needs to be included.

  - For a *quantitative study*, the theoretical framework should include a conceptualization of each of the concepts included in the study, hypotheses between the concepts in the study and an explanation for the expected relationships (hypotheses) between the constructs. This explanation should be based on theory and empirical insights. In a quantitative study, a conceptual model is presented at the end of this chapter.

  - In a *qualitative study*, a theoretical framing for the study should be provided. This means that you need to consider research that is relevant to and informs your research questions (i.e., sub research questions of the phenomenon under study). The framing often also discusses existing research and points to the gap in knowledge that is addressed in your study. In a qualitative study, a conceptual model is often not included.

- **Methodology** – The methodology explains how you conducted the research and includes an explanation and justification of the techniques used. This chapter should adhere to the guidelines for either quantitative or qualitative research.

  Quantitative study

  - Justification for research approach (why is a quantitative research approach suitable?)
  - Sample and procedure – how were the samples for your study collected, why in this way, what are the characteristics of the final sample included in your study?
  - Data collection technique – questionnaire or use of secondary data. Describe how the concepts were measured, justify why this is a valid and reliable approach (e.g., when you used a questionnaire make sure to discuss the results of the validity and reliability analyses (i.e., factor analyses and reliability analyses)
  - Data analysis strategy used (analysis strategy) – which strategy will you use to analyze the data? Explain the strategy you will use; describe any assumptions you tested.

  Qualitative study

  - Justification for research approach (why is a qualitative research approach suitable?)
  - Sample – discuss the sample universe and inclusion and exclusion criteria. Justify and explain those decisions. Describe the final sample included in your study (i.e., important characteristics/experiences).
  - Data collection technique and procedure – e.g., interviews or focus groups. Describe how the data was collected and the procedure used (e.g., from invitation to writing of transcripts).
  - Data analysis strategy – describe how the qualitative data analysis was performed.

  Mixed methods study

  - Justification for research approach (why is a mixed methods research approach suitable?)
  - Choose the appropriate method; typically, a case study method is used for mixed methods research. It can combine first a qualitative and then a quantitative method or the opposite.
  - This study follows a combination of both qualitative and quantitative research methods.

    Make sure to be very transparent about this procedure, it needs to be clear to a reader how you moved from the raw data to your actual findings and conclusions.

- Results
  - The results section should present the results of your research, focusing on an objective description of the results, not conclusions that can be drawn from them. Regarding quantitative research, you should also be specific with respect to your dataset and hypotheses/conceptual model (i.e., to find a positive correlation between rate of entrepreneurship as measured by business ownership and growth in gross domestic product). Consider the use of tables, attachments, the original questionnaire used, if any. Regarding qualitative research, you need to use the words and perspectives of your

informants, you need to provide a detailed overview (let the data speak), no summary or interpretation is provided in this chapter.

COMMENT: Prior to the final version of the project, you may present preliminary findings to your company or faculty supervisor; rearrange things etc. Do not include all these U-turns and revisions in the final piece unless your faculty supervisor instructs you to do so (and even so, better left for an appendix rather than confuse the reader by putting it in the main report). (Applies also to Discussion and Conclusion sections below).

- **Discussion – Conclusion/implications -** The following questions should also be addressed.:
  - How do your findings link back to the original problem statement, research question(s), and if applicable conceptual model? What are your contributions?
  - How do you answer your research questions? Make sure this is clearly addressed
  - Theoretical contributions.
  - **A conclusion** section should conclude the findings of the research. This should summarize the practical implications and make recommendations based on these findings.
  - Practical implications and well supported recommendations (bear in mind that this part carries 20% of the overall marks);
  - What are the limitations of your study; including key assumptions, methods used?
  - What would you suggest as future directions for research to follow up on your findings?

Reference list – Nyenrode has a standardized format for references, which can be found in the Rules and Regulations.

Appendices - The Appendices section should include anything that is not directly applicable to the main text e.g., questionnaires, list of interviewed people, raw data etc.

Design Science Research (DSR) is a comprehensive research approach that integrates multiple layers and methods. It draws on knowledge and techniques from both the natural and social sciences. The extent to which these methods are utilized varies depending on the specific design being developed. ***Therefore, participants engaging in DSR must be well-versed in traditional research methods. A robust and academically sound design relies on the proper application of these established methods***.

The participant wishing to use this method will be oriented towards a Faculty Supervisor specialized in this approach.